

08-09 Performance Review

Manager Review

Jonathan Daniel Micklos

Performance Review: 04/01/2008 - 03/31/2009

Reviewer: Devraj Varadhan

Role: Manager

Status: Completed

Manager: Devraj Varadhan

Overall Performance Summary

Employee Summary:

This has been my first few months at Amazon. So far, I have had the opportunity to work on and help to design a number of projects throughout Twister's technology portfolio. In addition I have worked various projects on my own which range from tools which internally help development and testing at Amazon to written business case studies and suggestions over Amazon.com. In doing so, I have worked various talented people and teams from all over Amazon.com. The people I have worked with, the experience I have gained and what I have learned in the last few months have been incredible.

Up until this point, I have spent my entire corporate computer science career (since the summer of 2003) interning for various companies across the mid-west, northwest and (of course) in Seattle (at Amazon Summer 2007). This change has presented me with various opportunities and challenges. The change has allowed me to grow as an innovating, big thinking, customer focused owner. I have been able to use my experiences in leadership and teamwork as the ACM President at Purdue with my Technological and Entrepreneurial experiences to help develop into a better SDE and Team Member of Twister, RCX and Amazon on the whole.

Manager Summary:

2008-09 performance year was the first performance year for you as a full time SDE in Amazon. Twister was first program / project for you in Amazon. You had a steady and moderately paced start with the team, twister software and the twister program as a whole. For the good part of 2008-09 performance year you have been working hard to integrate with the team, understand the software end-to-end and have had your equal share of wins & misses. However, since late Feb / early March this year, you have shown sudden acceleration / renewal of focus towards Twister as a solution which is evident in the results and how your teammates have started to rely on you. I attribute this to your overall understanding of the Twister system and your attitude. Keep it up! Its refreshing to see such a progress and I / Michael are truly looking forward to continue working with you this year on Twister. You have given the 2009-10 Twister goals a good start and are already showing key improvements in some of the areas that I have discussed below as your development areas. Congratulations on a good year. You are a terrific teammate, always willing to work hard and go the extra mile. I am very happy to have you on my team.

Thank you for all your efforts. Looking forward to you developing and delivering innovative and valuable solutions for our customers. Here's to an even more productive and action-packed 2009-10.

Performance Goals

Twister - Detail page & Search popover

Per the Twister Roadmap, launch Twister in 23 categories while improving code quality, detail page client side and server side performance. As part of the 23 categories, ensure that the software we deliver is scalable both functionally as well as from a performance standpoint

Employee Summary:

For category expansion, feature expansion, performance improvement and customer experience improvement I have approached Amazon.com from a very wide view. I have worked on code in the Twister and Merchandising Applications front end mason packages, Product Aggregator, CARS and Other Editions. Likewise, I have worked to help the development process at Amazon starting the ASIN Finder project (now handed off with the Item Finder team) and leading the Ubiquity adoption movement at Amazon (customizable command line interface for FireFox). In addition, I have taken time to analyze, document and address inadequacies in the Musical Instruments Store.

The development projects that I have worked on directly have involved multiple teams. These teams include Media Services, Gifting and the Product Aggregator Team. I have worked on end to end handling of images through CARS, Product Aggregator and Front End Mason. I have developed solutions for EMWA for Twister and CARS Video in CARS. I have increased the efficiency of detail page load time by continuing the spriting of the buy box, more buying choices box and button condo for US and EU locales. I have also fixed various problems in the Twister Detail Page Framework and MA Front End Mason.

Manager Summary:

Agree on the efforts & your various contributions in aiding twister launches WW. Truly appreciate your efforts. From your self-assessment and your peer feedback it is clear that you have focused on the breadth of contributions compared to depth. This has helped you learn varying degree of depths into systems - Twister as well as Amazon systems (not twister related). Your focus on tools such as ubiquity, ASIN finder is a good proof to your ownership and wanting to streamline the way we do things in Amazon. Keep it up! However, you need to have a balance in such a way that this focus isn't affecting your project deliverable which in turn affects your team goals. I have discussed this in development area section.

Overall, we had a successful year in Twister, launching in 19 categories WW. Thank you for all your contributions.

Operations - Incoming & Processing tickets

Maintain code quality & completeness to ensure that the incoming ticket flow & processing the tickets per the respective severity SLAs is well within the range of 5-10% of team's time

Employee Summary:

One of my main concentrations at Amazon has been on increasing code quality, decreasing ticket numbers and increasing the speed at which they are handled. For increasing code quality, I have worked with Neil in developing a process for documentation on the twister team. I believe that so long as it is not done to excess, documentation can be very helpful during code reviews and development and therefore increases code quality. I have made efforts towards having an archiveable solution for code reviews such as placing changes on wiki.

In regards to ticket processing and time allocation, I believe that the best way to limit the number of tickets as well as processing time is to limit the overall number of tickets in the open. We have begun giving out tickets in a round-robin fashion to the twister team members. This will soon be automated through Twister's Delorean Project. I personally try to keep tickets as low as possible in my queue. If

I have them build up, I make a point to attend to them as soon as possible (rather than allocating a specific amount of time each day). In this manner, I am able to address tickets in an expedient fashion. In addition, I have worked on the ASIN Finder project which will ultimately lower ticket number by virtue of providing better test data.

Manager Summary:

I agree on your individual contribution. However, overall as a team, we didn't meet this goal. As the year progressed and with the shift to focus on performance and lack of resources, we went several steps backwards on this goal. We should make concerted efforts in Q2 in meeting the 2009 operations goals. This level of focus is important as it allows us earn time to innovate on new solutions for our customers & business.

Twister Framework - Improvement

As we expand into newer categories and launching twister globally, its important to improve current twister framework to scale & seamlessly integrate with rest of the detail page features. Improve the framework to

(1) individual feature teams to integrate and modify their functionality without having to involve twister team. This enables them to operate autonomously and innovate faster. [Currently, the level of engagement that both twister & feature teams needs to go through and the centralization support of twister isn't efficient]

(2) simplify & improve new twister category expansion - unless a new category requires unique features there should be very little to no software development required to launch twister in a new category [Currently, every new category expansion requires several days of development & testing]

(3) single code path - Merge remainder of the cloned code paths to the main feature to eliminate twister specific versions completely

Employee Summary:

Of these three sub goals I have worked on everything but the single code path. With the new DPF, there are two main components that I have worked on. The first is the implementation of the twister feature-string-map. This is a central repository for features to store strings (instead of dealing with their own mechanisms). This straight forward tool allows for feature teams to seamlessly store strings on the detail page without worry of errors.

The other main component of the new DPF greatly simplifies feature adapter instantiation. Prior to this, adapters were created in the adapter factory on a case by case basis. My change consumes the twister app configuration information to instantiate each adapter on the fly. In this way, the addition of new adapters is now effortless and uniform. This is one technology that lets adapters just work.

Manager Summary:

Goal partially met and ongoing

This is an important goal for the team and twister program from a growth as well as operations standpoint. Secondly, this allows various features to integrate with twister seamlessly. DPF & SCP will continue into Q2 and I truly look forward to seeing you handle the remaining phases of the project in flight and yet to come with as much as grace and skill, and some improvements here and there, as you have in the 1st iteration.

Identify Strengths

Employee Summary:

I am an Owner and Innovator. I Think Big and am Customer Focused. I know that I must engage others and that in appropriate numbers, a team is often much more efficient than an individual. These are traits I have had since before working at Amazon. Since I have started working here, initiatives that I have started on my own include:

- Helping to solve the dearth of test ASINs at Amazon. I have detailed on a functional specification for finding ASINs in production which meet specific business use cases. After much research and work, it was determined that during that period a tool dubbed "Item Finder" had been released. This tool effectively accomplishes many of the same tasks that "ASIN Finder" would have. During this process I closely worked with the RCX QA Team in both functional requirements as well as high level technical ones. The hope was to eventually build this tool so that it would be integrated with the RCX QA Tool Chain. Once it was discovered that this tool was no longer needed, I held meetings to introduce Jason Patrao with the Item Finder team so that the project could be successfully handed off.
- Detailed out many of the inadequacies in the Musical Instruments Store at Amazon. I am a musician and know the community quite well. There were/are many places that the Musical Instruments Store could improve. I decided to author a document detailing these short comings. I submitted it to Devraj Varadhan, Dan Callies and others. While many of the smaller ideas that I had in the document were embraced (example: removing the requirement for merchants to list UPC numbers with instruments), larger ideas such as Recorded by Amazon and Amazon Music Rig were rejected as resources were not sufficient at the time.
- Started the ubiquity initiative at Amazon. Ubiquity is a customizable command line interface for FireFox. The commands are designed in JavaScript. This tool allows users to cross integrate various web services for simplified and direct control over the web. I hope to eventually have a community derived set of commands which streamline the day to day browsing processes at Amazon. So far, I have made quick searching tools for p4db to amazon.com as well as replacements existing tools such as an integrated version of phone-tool. Currently I am working on Apollo tools which would allow users to easily sync to parent stage, re-activate, etc. with only one command. With this project, I have the support of the EnvImprovement Ninjas for hosting the commands created thus far: <https://improvement-ninjas.amazon.com/Ubiquity/> I am also currently working with the monitoring team to create a set of tools for monitoring from Ubiquity. I am also adding sections for team specific command libraries. Using Twister as an example, there are various CARS commands which I already have slated for this initiative.

It has been one of my personal objectives on the Twister Team to gain a truly all-encompassing view of Twister. Outside of projects I have created on my own, I have been working on Twister, Product Aggregator and CARS. With this information I am able to be a better Owner in supporting and developing Twister end to end. I have worked closely with Neil Cutshaw and Anoop Balakrishnan on CARS and Product Aggregator. I have worked closely with Ryan Park on the New Twister DPF Framework and the planning behind many of its key components. I have likewise worked with Allen Chen on spriting of the Buy Box, More Buying Choices Box and the Button Condo. The overwhelming drive for these projects has been to improve the customer experience (examples: spriting, CARS EMWA, Various CARS Ranking and Interpretation Fixes) or improve the ability for us as engineers to develop for our customers (Examples: New Twister DPF Framework).

Manager Summary:

Your self identified strengths demonstrates your natural trait to streamline systems that is used widely and have a strong meaningful impact. I agree with your self assessment on your strengths. Other strengths that you have not noted for yourself but have demonstrated throughout the year is the ability to retain your Composure under pressure, and Teamwork and willingness to roll up sleeves.

Included below are some feedback from your peers:

Jon is very good at innovating and simplifying the software in our applications and especially in creating useful helper applications that can be used to quickly access information that is commonly needed in order to create good application software. A example of this is the ubiquity tool work that he has done, where he as created a documented set of helper bookmark tools to make it easier to access various tools such as wiki and the phone tool.

Jon also has solid interpersonal skills. Commonly he makes himself available to others to help provide information and guidance as needed. He is always approachable in my experience and has a friendly demeanor that make him easy to work and collaborate with. This has been especially evident when I have worked with Jon on code and design reviews and also in support operations around the detail page application.

He did a good job of trying to write functional requirements for an ASIN finder tool (find ASIN's with specific criteria for development and testing). During this process he discovered an existing Item Finder Tool which is currently very helpful for QA. His effort lead to the discovery of an existing tool and prevented duplicate effort/time on creating a new one.

Jon is extremely passionate about software development. He loves to innovate and find new ways of doing things that help developers and customers.

Jon is also very engaging and likes to learn and be involved in new initiatives. He is always open for discussion and is willing to ask for help when he needs it. He is also very receptive to the help that he receives.

One of Jon's biggest strengths I have noticed is his desire to improve Amazon in any way he can. He was and is still the driving force behind an ASIN finder tool that would help improve Twister developers and QA engineers find appropriate test ASINs. He also has a lot of good ideas that if implemented would help make our work here at Amazon a lot smoother

Very invested in solving technical problem and brings sound technical skills and an analytical mind.

Also constantly looks at other problem areas that be addressed and is always interested in addressing customer experience issues beyond the immediate problem domain.

Finds and shares solutions that help optimize routine tasks to help increase overall productivity.

Good communicator ; always verbalizing different approaches and aspects of a problem.

Identify Areas for Improvement

Employee Summary:

One arena that I am continuously working on (and need to work on) is in delivering results. I don't believe that thinking big and delivering results should be mutually exclusive. How one fails depends upon the goals set forth. I hold myself (and others) to high standards. Some projects that I have worked on hear have simply not come to fruition. As an example, I was working on a tool to create version sets from active environments in production. I was told that this was no longer needed and to put it down. What I should have done is finished it in my free time. I have seen other projects such as ASIN Finder not come to fruition. This is an example which is less my fault (a project already existed), still yet, less time should have been spent on it. In order to deliver more results with bigger ideas, I know that I will have to push and work harder and smarter. The concept of low hanging fruit holds true.

In addition to personal projects, I have seen sprinting fall through the cracks in production twice due to timing. I have been part of CARS Video which is still on hiatus. I do feel that a lot of the projects I work on for one reason or another are never delivered. My life is within my control. Very few things in my life are ever truly out of my control. With my aspirations, I create throughput and cause

deliverables to materialize if I ever wish to grow as a leader.

Manager Summary:

You have had a good share of wins & misses this year, as this being a first year for you at Amazon and Twister / DP is a complex area to start with. The key thing is, your perseverance and hard work in learning various facets of Twister is paying off now and since Feb this year you holding the fort solely on various aspects of Twister is superb. Keep it up! The most important thing that you should continue to do this year is stay focused and invest lot of time & efforts that directly contributes to Twister / DP and align your side innovations to that effect. Secondly, set a very high bar on code quality and defects so that they are built like world class medical systems. Your peers have echoed similar feedback and I have included some of the feedback below. We (I / Michael) are truly looking forward to your contributions in 2009-10 performance year.

Feedback from your peers:

Time management: Jon spends way too much time on relatively nonessential projects to the extent that the team's sprint is jeopardized. He has to be repeatedly reminded to focus on sprint tasks instead of personal side-projects. It would be good for Jon to learn to judge the difference between critical projects and nonessential projects (those that can be done when one has completed the main team project and has extra time)

Jon can become a good contributor to the team if he were mentored or paired up with a lead SDE to focus on these core SDE principles: Deliver Results, Innovate & Simplify, Customer Focus, Exercise Judgment.

Because Jon likes software so much, he comes up with a lot of new, innovate stuff to work on. However, this causes him to get very sidetracked in the day to day work. He spends time working on pet projects, which are undoubtedly useful, but this effects our sprint burn down a great deal.

Since Jon gets easily distracted with side projects, he has not been able to apply his technical skills to our team's projects. This makes it difficult to judge the quality of his code and software design

Jon is a great person to have on the team. He is engaging and outgoing. If he can get himself focused a bit more on the planned tasks at hand, I am sure he will be able to make great contributions

Can have tendency to always widen the scope of the problem , so that sometimes enough time and energy is not spent on solving the original specific issue.

Should record salient points of discussions to make sure he does not miss out on important details that were discussed.

Should make sure he provides effort estimates that can be closely followed a majority of the time and can improve time tracking skills.

Evaluate Management Abilities

Management Abilities

Hiring: How did you do hiring for your organization over the past year? Did you achieve your hiring objectives? Did you make good hiring decisions? (FC Managers Only: Discuss your participation in the hiring process.)

Coaching and Developing Employees: What are your coaching and development efforts that were most effective? What could you be doing more effectively to grow your employees?

Promoting: How do the recently promoted employees perform in your organization? Did you make

good promotion decisions?

Retaining: What have you done to retain high performing employees, including top talent?

Managing Performance: What have you done to manage underperforming employees in your organization?

Employee Summary:

Manager Summary:

Career Goals

Employee Summary:

Despite this, I truly miss managing teams and projects. At Purdue, I had numerous responsibilities that put me in positions requiring project and team management. In those capacities, I was able to lead others and help to mold them into the current leaders at Purdue. I miss this greatly.

I want to be able to lead Amazon in the business decisions that it takes in the future and drive the projects used to implement those ideas. Truly, the larger the influence it has, the happier I will be. I have already begun by recommending those at Purdue who I have personally worked with and I look forward to hopefully working with them at Amazon.

Ultimately, I wish to progress along the management track at Amazon as soon as prudent.

Manager Summary:

Michael will be working with you to set the 2009 goals and I'll be supporting him as needed. As part of that, we will jointly work with you to find opportunities that allows you to play multiple roles across our 2009-10 projects.

Development Activities

Santana Training

Minimizing tickets as well as pushing twister into the future with category and feature expansion, it is crucial that I stay aware of new technologies at Amazon. One such technology is Manaus. Manaus is part of the Santana website application platform. Manaus is the replacement for gurupa and is driven by java (instead of perl mason). This offers many features, among which include native multi threading.

I have taken this class in order to stay up to date with this technology. I would like to use this knowledge to begin bringing Manaus to the detail page and twister.

Employee Summary:

I have taken this class. It was quite insightful. I have yet to actually start pushing for Manaus use in the detail page. Despite this, I will hopefully start talking to Dan Riffero in the near future in regards to this.

Manager Summary:

Expand Language Literacy

While at Amazon for the first half year, I will learn Perl, Perl Mason and Ruby. This will allow me to work on the front end Mason, Product Aggregator and numerous Ruby scripts at Amazon.

Employee Summary:

I am fairly comfortable with Perl and Perl Mason at this point. Likewise, I have begun using Ruby on my own for CGI in my Ubiquity efforts. In one such example, I am have written a Ruby CGI which dumps a JSON object representing a user's phone tool information.

Manager Summary:

Ratings

Performance Rating: Achieves

Leadership Principles Rating: Solid Strength